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Tharifith

Riffian Language Course

LESSON 8

Verb Conjugation

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A Comprehensive Guide for Beginners Created by LEARN THARIFITH

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1. Introduction to Tharifith Verbs

The verbal system is one of the most distinctive and fascinating aspects of Tharifith grammar/ conjugation. Unlike English, which relies heavily on auxiliary verbs and complex tense formations, Tharifith verbs convey tense, aspect, and mood through internal changes to the verb stem and a system of prefixes and suffixes. This morphological richness allows speakers to express nuanced temporal and aspectual distinctions with remarkable economy. Understanding how verbs work in Tharifith is essential for moving beyond basic vocabulary to genuine fluency in the language.

Tharifith verbs are built from consonantal roots, typically consisting of three consonants, which carry the core semantic meaning. These roots are then modified by vowels and affixes to create different verb forms and indicate grammatical relationships. For example, the root K-R-Z (to plow) can generate various forms depending on who is performing the action and when it occurs. Ex : iKaReZ (plowing, aKRaZ : the action of plowing, imKRZ : The plowing tool …). This root-and-pattern system is characteristic of Afroasiatic languages and gives Tharifith its distinctive morphological character. While this may seem complex at first, the system is remarkably regular once the basic patterns are understood.

Tharifith has three main verbal forms that correspond roughly to different temporal and aspectual categories: the imperative (used for commands), the aorist forms (present and future actions), and the preterite (used for past actions). Each of these forms has its own conjugation pattern, and mastering these patterns is the key to expressing yourself effectively in Tharifith. Additionally, there is a negative form for each positive form, creating a symmetrical system that allows for precise expression of both positive and negative statements. This lesson will guide you through each of these forms systematically, providing clear examples and practice opportunities.

2. Verb Structure and Root System

Before diving into conjugation patterns, it is essential to understand the underlying structure of Tharifith verbs. Most verbs in Tharifith are derived from triconsonantal roots (ie: sequences of three consonants) that carry the basic meaning of the verb. These roots are not words themselves but abstract patterns from which actual verb forms are constructed. The vowels that appear between the consonants, along with any prefixes or suffixes, determine the specific

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grammatical form of the verb. This system allows for a highly productive and regular way of creating and modifying verbs.

2.1 Understanding Verb Roots

Below are examples of common verb roots and their meanings. The root is shown in capital letters, followed by the basic verb form and its meaning.

Root	Basic Form	Meaning
K-R-Z	ikrez	to plow
S-W-R	isiwar	to talk
W-Th	Iwtha	to hit
Kh-S	ikhes	to like/love
Dh-W-R	Idhwer	to go back
N-GH	Ingha	to kill
Dh-W	idhwa	to fly

2.2 Verb Patterns

Verbs in Tharifith follow predictable patterns based on their root structure. The most common verb pattern has the form i-C_1(i,e,a)C_2eC_3 in the third person masculine singular of the preterite (past tense), where C_1, C_2, and C_3 represent the three root consonants. Understanding this pattern helps you recognize and produce correct verb forms. For example, from the root K-R-Z (plow), we get 'ikerez' (he plowed). Verbs with fewer than three root consonants follow different patterns, as we will see in the section on irregular verbs.

3. The Imperative Mode

The imperative is the simplest verb form in Tharifith and serves as a good starting point for understanding the verbal system. The imperative is used for giving commands and making requests. In Tharifith, the imperative has different forms depending on who is being addressed: singular masculine, singular feminine, and plural. This gender and number distinction in the imperative reflects the importance of social context in Riffian communication, where addressing someone correctly is a matter of cultural propriety.

3.1 Imperative Formation

The basic imperative form (masculine and feminine singular) is typically identical to or derived from the verb stem. The plural is formed by adding the suffix '-m' for a male group or group that contains at least one male, or by adding the suffix '-nt' if the group is completely female group. The table below shows the imperative forms for several common verbs.

Root	Verb	Masc.& Fem. Sing.	Mas. Plur.	Fem. Plur.
K-R-Z	Krez	Krez	Karz-m	Karz-nt
S-W-R	Siwr	Siwr	Siwr-m	Siwr-nt
W-Th	Weth	Weth	Wthe-m	Wthe-nt
Kh-S	Khes	Khes	Khse-m	Khse-nt
Dh-Gw-R	Dhwer	Dhwer	Dhewr-m	Dhewr-nt
N-GH	Negh	Negh	Nghe-m	Nghe-nt
Dh-W	Dhew	Dhew	Dhwe-m	Dhwe-nt

3.2 Using the Imperative in Context

The imperative is often accompanied by the particle 'a' which softens the command or adds a sense of immediacy. This particle is frequently used when making requests rather than issuing direct commands. Additionally, the object pronouns can be attached to imperative forms to indicate who is being affected by the action.

Tharifith
a Krez
a Siwr
a Weth
a Khes
a Dhwer

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4. The Aorist (Basic Present/Future)

The aorist is one of the two main finite verb forms in Tharifith, used primarily for expressing present and future actions. Unlike English, which has separate present and future tenses, Tharifith uses the aorist for both, with context or time expressions clarifying the intended meaning. The aorist is formed by adding person-specific prefixes and suffixes to the verb stem. This form is fundamental to everyday communication, as it is used to describe ongoing actions, habitual activities, and future plans.

4.1 Aorist Conjugation Pattern

The aorist is characterized by a specific set of prefixes and suffixes that mark person, gender, and number. The basic pattern uses the prefix 'ad' (or 'a' before certain consonants) combined with person markers. The table below shows the complete conjugation pattern using the verb 'raḥ' (to go).

Person	Tharifith	English
1st sing.	ad raḥegh	I go/will go
2nd sing. m.	ad t-raḥeḍ	you go (masc)
2nd sing. f.	ad t-raḥeḍ	you go (fem)
3rd sing. m.	ad i-raḥ	he goes
3rd sing. f.	ad t-raḥ	she goes
1st plural	ad ne-raḥ	we go
2nd plural m.	ad t-raḥ-m	you go (masc pl)
2nd plural f.	ad t-raḥ-nt	you go (fem pl)
3rd plural m.	ad raḥ-n	they go (masc)
3rd plural f.	ad raḥ-nt	they go (fem)

4.2 Recognizing Aorist Patterns

The aorist conjugation follows a consistent pattern that can be recognized across most verbs. The key markers are: 'ad' (the particle), 't-' for second person and third person feminine singular, 'i-' for third person masculine singular, and 'ne-' for first person plural. The suffixes '-m', '-nt',

'-n', and '-nt' mark second person plural and third person plural. Notice that the verb stem itself may undergo slight vowel changes depending on the conjugation. With practice, these patterns become automatic, allowing you to conjugate new verbs correctly.

5. The Preterite (Past Tense)

The preterite is the primary past tense form in Tharifith, used to describe completed actions in the past. Unlike the aorist, the preterite does not use the particle 'ad'—instead, person, gender, and number are marked entirely through prefixes and suffixes attached to a modified verb stem. The preterite is essential for narrating past events, telling stories, and describing actions that have been completed. Mastering the preterite is crucial for communicating about personal experiences, historical events, and any actions that occurred in the past.

5.1 Preterite Conjugation Pattern

The preterite is formed with a different set of prefixes and suffixes than the aorist. The verb stem also typically undergoes a vowel change (often involving 'e' becoming another vowel or disappearing). The table below shows the preterite conjugation using the verb 'raḥ' (to go), with the past form.

Person	Tharifith	English
1st sing.	raḥeɣ	I went
2nd sing. m.	th-raḥeḍ	you went (masc)
2nd sing. f.	th-raḥeḍ	you went (fem)
3rd sing. m.	i-raḥ	he went
3rd sing. f.	th-raḥ	she went
1st plural	n-raḥ	we went
2nd plural m.	th-raḥe-m	you went (masc pl)
2nd plural f.	th-raḥe-nt	you went (fem pl)
3rd plural m.	raḥe-n	they went (masc)
3rd plural f.	raḥe-nt	they went (fem)

5.2 Preterite of Common Verbs

Below are the preterite forms of several common verbs in the third person masculine singular. Notice how different verbs form their preterite stem in slightly different ways. Some verbs maintain their root vowels, while others undergo modifications. These variations are largely predictable based on the consonants of the root.

Verb Root	Aorist (he goes)	Preterite (he went)	Meaning
K-R-Z	ad i-krez	i-krez	to plow
S-W-R	ad i-siwer	i-siwer	to speak
W-Th	ad i-weth	i-wtha	to hit
Kh-S	ad i-khes	i-khes	to like/love
Dh-Gw-R	ad i-dhwer	i-dhwer	to go back
N-GH	ad i-negh	i-ngha	to kill

6. The Negative Preterite

The negative preterite is used to express that an action did not happen in the past. In Tharifith, negation involves a different verb form than the simple preterite, along with negative particles. The negative system is remarkably systematic: each positive form has a corresponding negative form with its own distinctive morphology. This symmetry between positive and negative forms is a characteristic feature of Berber languages and allows for precise expression of negation in different tenses and aspects.

6.1 Negation Pattern

The negative preterite is formed by surrounding the verb with the negative particles 'ur' (before) and 'chi/cha' (after). The verb itself takes a different form, often with the prefix 'i-' for masculine and “th-“ for feminine, and specific suffixes. The table below shows the negative preterite of 'raḥ' (to go).

Person	Tharifith	English
1st sing.	ur raḥegh chi / cha	I didn't go
2nd sing. m.	Ur thraḥeḍ chi / cha	you didn't go (masc)
2nd sing. f.	Ur thraḥeḍ chi / cha	you didn't go (fem)
3rd sing. m.	Ur iraḥ chi / cha	he didn't go
3rd sing. f.	Ur thraḥ chi / cha	she didn't go
1st plural	Ur nraḥ chi / cha	we didn't go
3rd plural m.	Ur raḥn chi / cha	they didn't go (masc)
3rd plural f.	Ur raḥnt chi / cha	they didn't go (fem)

6.2 Negative Aorist

The negative aorist follows a similar pattern, using the particles 'ur' and 'chi /cha' around a modified verb form. This is used to express that something does not happen or will not happen.

Person	Positive Aorist	English	Negative Aorist	English
1st sing.	ad raḥegh	I will go	ur traḥegh chi / cha	I don't/won't go
3rd sing. m.	ad i-raḥ	he will go	ur it-raḥ chi / cha	he doesn't/won't go
3rd sing. f.	ad t-raḥ	she will go	ur t-raḥ chi / cha	she doesn't/won't go
1st plural	ad n-raḥ	we will go	ur nt-raḥ chi / cha	we don't/won't go
3rd plural	ad raḥen	they will go	ur t-raḥen chi / cha	they don't/won't go

7. Common Verb Conjugations

To help you practice and internalize the conjugation patterns, this section presents complete conjugations of several of the most frequently used verbs in Tharifith. Study these examples carefully, noting how the prefixes and suffixes change across persons and how the verb stem may undergo modifications. Once you have mastered these common verbs, you will be able to

apply the same patterns to many other verbs in the language. Remember that the best way to learn conjugations is through practice and repetition, so return to these tables frequently as you develop your Tharifith skills.

7.1 'ikhes' – To love / to like / to want

Person	Aorist(Pr-Fut)	Preterite (Past)	Negative Aorist	Negative Preterite
I	ad khsegh	Khsegh	Ur khsegh chi/cha	Ur khsegh chi/cha
You m.	ad t-khsedh	Th-khsedh	Ur t-khsedh chi/cha	Ur th-khsedh chi/cha
You. f.	ad t-khsedh	Th-khsedh	Ur t-khsedh chi/cha	Ur th-khsedh chi/cha
He	ad i-khes	I-khes	Ur i-khes chi/cha	Ur i-khes chi/cha
She	ad t-khes	Th-khes	Ur t-khes chi/cha	Ur th-khes chi/cha
We	ad n-khes	N-khes	Ur n-khes chi/cha	Ur n-khes chi/cha
You m	ad t-khsem	Th-khsem	Ur t-khsem chi/cha	Ur th-khsem chi/cha
You f	ad t-khsent	Th-khsent	Ur t-khsent chi/cha	Ur th-khsent chi/cha
Them m.	ad khsen	Khsen	Ur khsen chi/cha	Ur khsen chi/cha
Them f.	ad khsent	Khsent	Ur khsent chi/cha	Ur khsent chi/cha

8. Irregular Verbs

While most Tharifith verbs follow the conjugation patterns presented above, there are several important irregular verbs that have unique forms. These verbs are among the most frequently used in the language, so mastering their conjugations is essential. Irregularity in Tharifith verbs often involves verbs with fewer than three root consonants, or verbs that have undergone historical sound changes that have made their patterns irregular. The most important irregular verbs are 'iri' (to be), 'ghari' (to have). These verbs require special attention and memorization.

8.1 'Iri' - To Be

The verb 'to be' is highly irregular in Tharifith and appears in several different forms depending on context. In many cases, Tharifith uses a zero copula (no verb at all) for equational sentences.

When the verb 'to be' is needed, it typically appears in its aorist or preterite forms as shown below.

Person	Aorist	Preterite	Meaning
1st sing.	ad irigh	djigh	I am/was
2nd sing. m.	ad t-iriḍ	th-djiḍ	you are/were (masc)
3rd sing. m.	ad i-ri	i-dja	he is/was
3rd sing. f.	ad t-iri	th-dja	she is/was
1st plural	ad n-iri	n-dja	we are/were
3rd plural	ad iri-n	djan	they are/were

Please click here to watch the youtube video "Verb to be in present & past tense "

9. Using Verbs in Context

Understanding conjugation patterns is only the first step, being able to use verbs correctly in context is the ultimate goal. This section provides examples of verbs used in complete sentences, demonstrating how verb forms interact with subjects, objects, and other sentence elements. Pay attention to word order, which in Tharifith typically follows a Verb-Subject-Object (VSO) pattern, though this can vary depending on focus and emphasis. Also note how object pronouns attach to verbs and how temporal expressions clarify whether an aorist form refers to present or future time.

9.1 Simple Sentences

Tharifith	English
Ahamuch i-ẓra	the boy saw (something)
Thahamuchth th-ẓra	the girl saw (something)
Ahamuch iẓar / Ahamuch ad-iẓar	the boy sees/will see
Ahamuch i-ẓra aghrum	the boy saw the bread
i-khes adich	he liked to eat
ad i-rah a thadath	he will go to the house

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9.2 Verbs with Object Pronouns

Object pronouns in Tharifith attach directly to the verb, appearing after the verb stem but before any suffixes. This creates complex verb forms that incorporate both subject marking (through prefixes) and object marking (through attached pronouns). The table below shows examples of verbs with attached object pronouns.

Tharifith	English
Netta i-ẓra-i	he saw me
Netta i-ẓra-chek	he saw you (masc)
Netta i-ẓra-chem	he saw you (fem)
Netta i-ẓra-th	he saw him/it (masc)
Netta i-ẓra-t	he saw her/it (fem)
Netta i-ẓra-negh	he saw us
Netta i-ẓra-chkom	he saw you (plural)
Netta i-ẓra-then	he saw them (masc)
Netta i-ẓra-thent	he saw them (fem)

9.3 Expressing Time

Since the aorist can express both present and future, temporal expressions are often used to clarify the intended meaning. The examples below show how time words specify whether an aorist verb refers to present or future time.

Tharifith	English
nhara ad i-rah	today he goes (present)
thiwcha ad i-rah	tomorrow he will go (future)
iḍenat i-rah	yesterday he went (past)
rokha ad ẓagh	now I see (present)

10. Practice Exercises

The following exercises will help you practice the verb conjugation patterns presented in this lesson. Work through each exercise carefully, and refer back to the conjugation tables as needed. Remember that mastering verb conjugation requires practice, return to these exercises multiple times until the patterns become automatic.

Exercise 1: Imperative Formation

Provide the feminine singular and plural imperative forms for each verb.

1. raḥ (go) → Mas. / fem. sing. _____ Mas. plural _____ Fem. plural _____
2. dhwer (come back) → Mas. / fem. sing. _____ Mas. plural _____ Fem. plural _____
3. ari (go up) → Mas. / fem. sing. _____ Mas. plural _____ Fem. plural _____
4. Dhew (fly) → Mas. / fem. sing. _____ Mas. plural _____ Fem. plural _____
5. siwer (speak) → Mas. / fem. sing. _____ Mas. plural _____ Fem. plural _____

Exercise 2: Aorist Conjugation

Conjugate the verb 'khes' (to want) in the aorist for the following persons.

1. I want: _____
2. You want (masc. sing.): _____
3. She wants: _____
4. We want: _____
5. They want (masc. pl.): _____

Exercise 3: Preterite Conjugation

Conjugate the verb 'iẓer' (to see) in the preterite (past) for the following persons.

1. I saw: _____
2. He saw: _____
3. She saw: _____
4. We saw: _____
5. They saw (fem. pl.): _____

Exercise 4: Negation

Convert the following positive statements into negative statements.

1. ẓrigh (I saw) → _____
2. ad i-rah (he will go) → _____
3. i-khes (he liked) → _____

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4. ad i-khes (he wants) → _____

5. raḍ-n (they went) → _____

Exercise 5: Translation

Translate the following sentences into Tharifith.

1. I am going to the market. _____
2. She saw me yesterday. _____
3. We don't want bread. _____
4. They (fem.) came today. _____
5. He didn't like the tea. _____

11. Answer Key

Exercise 1: Imperative Formation

Exercise 2: Aorist Conjugation

Exercise 3: Preterite Conjugation

Exercise 4: Negation

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Exercise 5: Translation

12. Lesson Summary

In this lesson, you have acquired a comprehensive understanding of the Tharifith verbal system, one of the most important and complex aspects of the language. You have learned about the triconsonantal root system that underlies most Tharifith verbs, and how vowels and affixes modify these roots to create different verb forms. The three main verb forms (the imperative, aorist, and preterite) have been presented with their conjugation patterns, allowing you to express commands, present/future actions, and past actions respectively.

You have also mastered the negative system, learning how ’ur...chi/cha’ surrounds modified verb forms to create negative statements. The conjugation patterns for common verbs like 'ẓer' (to see), 'khes' (to like) have been presented in full, providing models that can be applied to many other verbs. The irregular verbs 'iri' (to be), 'dhwer' (to go back), and 'awḍ' (to arrive/take) require special attention and memorization, but their high frequency makes this effort worthwhile.

Key concepts from this lesson include: the prefixes marking second person, third person masculine, and first person plural; the suffixes '-m', '-n', and '-nt' marking gender and number in plural forms; the particle 'ad' marking the aorist; and the negative particles 'ur' and 'chi/cha'. Remember that context and time expressions help clarify whether an aorist form refers to present or future time. With continued practice, these conjugation patterns will become automatic, allowing you to express yourself fluently in Tharifith across a range of temporal and aspectual contexts.

The foundation you have built here will serve you well as you continue to develop your Tharifith language skills.

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